



Inflation Climbs to a Three-Year High, Driven Mostly by Energy

Teacher copy (everything in the student copy, plus answers and teaching notes)

The following lays out what the May 2026 Consumer Price Index report shows about the pace of inflation, and where most of the month's increase came from.

The article, marked for rhetorical devices (one color throughout):

1 Consumer prices are climbing faster again. The Bureau of Labor Statistics reported on June 10 that the Consumer Price Index, the government's main measure of what households pay for goods and services, rose 0.5 percent in May, putting prices 4.2 percent above where they stood a year earlier. That is the fastest twelve-month pace since April 2023, and a step up from April's annual rate of 3.8 percent. [Logos] The bureau adjusts its monthly figures for ordinary seasonal swings, so the May increase is not a quirk of the calendar.

2 Energy did most of the lifting. [Metaphor] The energy index rose 3.9 percent in May alone and stands 23.5 percent higher than it did a year ago; energy supplied more than 60 percent of the month's overall increase. Gasoline is the extreme case inside that category, up 40.5 percent from a year earlier. A tank of gas that cost 50 dollars last May costs about 70 now.

3 The rest of the report tells a quieter story. The core measure, which sets aside food and energy because both swing widely from month to month, rose 0.2 percent in May and 2.9 percent over the past year. Economists watch that steadier number because it shows what prices are doing once the loudest movers are taken out. Food rose 0.2 percent for the month and 3.1 percent over the year. Shelter, the housing portion of the index, went up 0.3 percent, half its 0.6 percent gain in April. Set food and energy aside and inflation runs just under 3 percent a year; count them back in and it runs above 4. [Antithesis]

4 There is a fair way to read May as a narrower problem than its headline number: the core rate is under 3 percent, and shelter slowed rather than sped up. [Concession] The qualification is that nobody pays the core rate. A family's gasoline and grocery bills sit inside the all-items number and outside the core one, and the all-items number is the one that moved from 3.8 percent to 4.2 between one report and the next. Whether energy keeps pushing it upward is a question the May report raises and does not answer.

Devices, and why they are here:

Logos (paragraph 1): "The Bureau of Labor Statistics reported on June 10 that the Consumer Price Index, the government's main measure of what households pay for goods and services, rose 0.5 percent in May, putting prices 4.2 percent above where they stood a year earlier. That is the fastest twelve-month pace since April 2023, and a step up from April's annual rate of 3.8 percent."

Builds the opening claim on attributed government data, with the agency, the date, and checkable figures all present in the first sentences, so the authority rests on the documented record rather than the writer's assertion.

Metaphor (paragraph 2): “Energy did most of the lifting.”

Compresses the report's finding that energy supplied most of the month's increase into one plain physical image of lifting, letting a single quiet figure of speech announce the paragraph's subject without any emotional coloring.

Antithesis (paragraph 3): “Set food and energy aside and inflation runs just under 3 percent a year; count them back in and it runs above 4.”

Holds the two ways of measuring the same month in balanced, parallel clauses, the under-3-percent core reading against the above-4-percent full reading, so the gap between them is felt as a contrast rather than merely reported.

Concession (paragraph 4): “There is a fair way to read May as a narrower problem than its headline number: the core rate is under 3 percent, and shelter slowed rather than sped up.”

Grants the calmer reading of the report its genuine force before qualifying it, which keeps the voice fair to the evidence and makes the qualification that follows land as a conclusion the facts compel rather than an opinion the writer brought.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. The relationship between the second and third paragraphs is best described as one in which the writer first ____ and then ____.
 - A) proves that energy alone will set the course of future inflation, and then dismisses the remaining categories entirely
 - B) isolates the largest source of the month's increase, and then turns to the categories where prices stayed calmer
 - C) concedes that prices barely moved in May, and then argues that the report overstates the problem
 - D) explains how the bureau adjusts its monthly figures, and then questions whether that adjustment can be trusted
2. In the third paragraph, the writer's use of balanced clauses in the sentence beginning "Set food and energy aside" serves primarily to ____
 - A) instruct readers to recalculate their own cost of living without food and energy
 - B) soften the report's findings by presenting them as a matter of perspective
 - C) imply that the government designed two indexes to satisfy different audiences
 - D) sharpen the contrast between two readings of the same month's prices

Multiple choice answer key:

1. **Answer B.** The second paragraph singles out energy as the supplier of most of the month's increase, and the third moves to the core measure, food, and shelter, the categories that rose more slowly. The option about conceding that prices barely moved inverts the piece's actual opening claim that prices are climbing faster. The option about the seasonal adjustment describes material from the first paragraph, not the second, and the report's adjustment is never doubted. The option about proving energy's future course uses absolute wording the passage never supports; the piece confines itself to what one month's record shows.

2. Answer D. The paired clauses hold the under-3-percent core reading directly against the above-4-percent full reading so the gap between them lands in a single breath. The softening option names a real move, balance, but assigns it a purpose the paragraph does not serve, since the sentence heightens rather than blurs the difference. The recalculating option takes the imperative phrasing literally, as if the sentence were advice instead of a framing device. The two-audiences option imports a motive about the government's design of its statistics that the passage never states.

Discussion questions:

1. The writer spends a full paragraph on the calmer core, food, and shelter numbers before setting them aside with "nobody pays the core rate." What does giving the quieter reading that much space do for the writer's credibility, and what would the piece lose if that paragraph were cut?
2. The piece closes on "a question the May report raises and does not answer." Why might a writer in this evidence-forward voice refuse to end on a verdict, and how would the tone change if the piece ended on the gasoline figure instead?

Sample strong discussion responses:

1. Giving the quieter numbers a full paragraph is the writer's central credibility move. By presenting the core rate, food, and shelter fairly and at length before qualifying them, the writer shows the conclusion was weighed rather than assumed; the concession costs the argument something, which is exactly why the qualification that follows, that nobody pays the core rate, reads as a judgment the evidence forced. Without that paragraph the piece would still be accurate, but it would read as a one-sided alarm about energy, and the level, adjudicating authority the voice depends on would collapse.
2. Refusing a verdict is consistent with the whole posture of the piece: the writer claims only what the record supports, and one month of data cannot establish whether the climb will continue. Ending on the open question keeps the authority where the piece has placed it all along, in the documented figures, and leaves the reader holding exactly as much certainty as the report provides. Ending on the 40.5 percent gasoline number instead would make the final note loud and alarming, a closing flourish the rest of the prose deliberately avoids, and it would tip the even, evidence-forward tone toward advocacy.

Writing prompt (AP Q3-style argument):

In the final paragraph, the writer observes that "nobody pays the core rate": the measure economists watch most closely is one no household ever experiences directly. Write an essay that argues your position on whether simplified measures of a complicated reality, in economics or elsewhere, clarify more than they conceal. Use appropriate, specific evidence to illustrate and develop your position.

Common misconceptions to watch for:

- Reading 4.2 percent as May's one-month increase. The monthly rise was 0.5 percent; 4.2 percent is the change over the twelve months ending in May.
- Treating the final paragraph's granted claim as the writer's position. The narrower reading of May is a concession the writer then qualifies, not the conclusion the piece reaches.
- Labeling the balanced "Set food and energy aside" sentence anaphora. No word repeats at the start of successive clauses; contrasting ideas carried in parallel structure is antithesis.

- Assuming the core measure excludes food and energy because they do not matter. The piece gives the actual reason: both categories swing widely from month to month, so removing them shows the steadier underlying trend.

AP exam alignment:

MCQ 1 targets Reasoning and Organization (Skill Category 5: the relationship between paragraphs within the line of reasoning). MCQ 2 targets Style (Skill Category 7: how balanced syntax serves the writer's purpose). The writing prompt is an AP Q3-style argument that generalizes the passage's contestable premise about simplified measures. All marked devices (logos, metaphor, antithesis, concession) are drawn from the controlled AP device vocabulary, and the headnote follows the AP exam's italic occasion-line convention for an impersonal passage.